Politically Correct The Princess and the Pea

By James Finn Garner

NARRATOR: In a kingdom over the hills and far away, there lived a young prince who was very full of himself. He was healthy, relatively handsome, and had had more than his fair share of happiness and comfort growing up. Yet he felt that he deserved something more. It was not enough for him to have been born into a life of parasitical leisure and to keep the masses firmly under the heel of his calfskin boots. He was also determined to perpetuate this undemocratic tyranny by marrying only a real, authentic, card-carrying princess.

INTRODUCTION

And so begins the story of the Princess and the Pea . . . You remember the story . . . the one with the moral that goes something like this . . . if you are extremely sensitive and fussy about your own physical comfort, and complain to your host about small imperfections, instead of being tactful and polite; then you are special and deserve to marry a handsome prince and live happily ever after.

Yeah, right . . . . Somehow I cannot imagine the princess from this story living "happily ever after." If she was sensitive enough to be bothered by a pea under a gazillion mattresses, then how in the world would she cope when the honeymoon was over and the prince started leaving the toilet seat up?

Fortunately, James Finn Garner gives us an alternate version . . . a politically correct version of The Princess and the Pea.

FOR EDUCATIO

NARRATOR: His mother, the queen, encouraged her son's obsession, despite the obvious risks of hemophiliac or microcephalic grandchildren. Many years earlier, after a period of inadequate wellness, his father the king had achieved corporal terminality. This lack of a strong male presence gnawed at the

prince on a subconscious level, and no amount of weekend retreats and male bonding with other young dukes and barons could relieve this anxiety. His mother, for her own codependent and Oedipal reasons, did not bother to change or correct his selfish notions or unattainable perfection in a spousal lifemate.

In his quest for the perfect partner, the prince travelled far and wide, looking for someone to enslave in matrimony. Astride his trusty equine colleague, he went from kingdom to queendom and from dukedom to duchessdom, asking for names and phone numbers. Heavily or lightly pigmented, vertically or horizontally challenged, cosmetically attractive or differently visaged – he cared not a whit. His only criterion was the royal authenticity of a wommon who could share his regal delusions of privilege and persunal worth.

One rainy night, after a long journey to many far-off bioregions, the prince nourished himself with a bowl of lentil-curry stew and confided his fears to his mother:

PRINCE: I don't think I'll ever find a genuine princess with whom to share my life, Mummy.

QUEEN: Well, Son, don't forget the many benefits of the single life. Don't let society and the church pressure you into a lifestyle for which you might not be suited.

PRINCE: Perhaps I should widen my scope a bit.

QUEEN: What? And throw out your standards?

PRINCE: No, Mummy, perhaps I have fallen into a trap of the orthodox heterosexualist majority. Maybe there's a fine young ***prince*** out there for me. It's at least worth a try.

NARRATOR: Before his mother could answer, there was a knock on the castle door. The servants pulled open the heavy portal, and out of the rain stepped a young wommon, who was moisture-enhanced from head to foot. She was certainly attractive to the eye, if you're the type of shallow person who attached value to appearances. Luckily for our story, the prince was not one of those types. He had one standard, and only one standard, classist though it might have been. Imagine the prince's surprise when the visitor blurted out,

PRINCESS: A princess shouldn't be out in weather like this!

NARRATOR: Well now, ***this*** was a revelation straight from the equine animal companion's mouth! The prine was struck orally inoperative for a moment, then invited the dryness-challenged visitor to enjoy their hospitality in the castle overnight.

While this was certainly a joyous development for the prince, his mother felt very threatened that someone was taking her son away from her. But rather than acknowledging the validity of her feelings and airing them in a constructive way, the queen decided on a ruse to test the visitor's claim. She sneaked up to the bedchambers and found the room where the persun of saturation would be sleeping. She tore off all the bedding from the frame and placed one single pea on the bed slats. Then she placed 10 futons on top of the pea, and on top of that, 10 eiderdown quilts.

QUEEN: There. If that drenched wench downstairs is really a princess, she will be refined enough to notice this lump and be unable to sleep.

NARRATOR: The next morning at breakfast, over the royal granola, the queen innocently asked the young wommon how she had slept.

PRINCESS: Abominably. I didn't get a wink all night. First of all, the bed was piled high with eiderdown quilts. Barbaric! How could I sleep, thinking of the poor naked geese who surrendered their feather for my comfort? Then, as I was removing the extra futons to share them with some of the less fortunate peasants living around the castle, I found a pea placed beneath them all. Shocking, with the state of the world as it is, that someone would waste food like that.

NARRATOR: With these statements, the queen nearly choked on her soy milk. The prince, who had learned of his mother's scheme to screen out a princess, was so excited he couldn't keep silent any longer.

PRINCE: So you really are a princess!

PRINCESS: Last night I was, yes. Last night I was a princess; this morning I'm an ancient Viking warrior. Oh, you sillies – I'm channeling! I have over a dozen past persunalities that periodically inhabit my body – everyone from Charlemagne's mistress to Aesop's brother-in-law. And Cleopatra. But then, everyone's been Cleopatra at some time or other. Let me tell you, it makes for some interesting conversation at parties! It's all pretty exciting for an economically disadvantaged spoonmaker's daughter who grew up on the wrong side of the drainage ditch."

NARRATOR: These revelations made the queen very angry, but the prince was intrigued.

PRINCE: So, when do you think you will be channeling a princess again?

PRINCESS: A week from Tuesday, mid-morning until early evening. I am very punctual with my past lives.

PRINCE: Then on that Tuesday afternoon I will ask you to be my wife and castle-mate, and you can rule by my side as an equal partner in every way.

PRINCESS: *(considering a moment)* I would gladly accept, if not for the fact that this morning, as I have said, I am a Viking warrior – Liefdahl by name, son of

Ulfdahl – and I have a strong notion to lay siege to your castle just after breakfast.

QUEEN: How rude! We give her lodging in a storm and breakfast the next morning, and she swaps persunalities on us and calmly talks about laying siege to us, without so much as a 'by your leave'!

PRINCE: Mother, please. Now how long are you generally a Viking warrior?

PRINCESS: Oh, no longer than 45 minutes. After that, I'm usually the hermit St. Giles, living in a hovel and renouncing all worldly possessions.

PRINCE: And that would include . . . ?

PRINCESS: That would include (smiling) renouncing any and all worldly kingdoms conquered by my other spiritual co-habitators.

NARRATOR: So, as is often the case, timing was crucial to a happy ending to our story. The "princess" and the prince were married the second Tuesday following, in accordance with her metaphysical timetable, and they had a very happy honeymoon, especially during certain transformation. Every time she became Liefdal, son of Ulfdahl, she would conquer the prince and his castle, and every time she became St. Giles, she would give it right back. Channeling past lives and historical persunalities became *de rigueur* in court from that day forward, and the queen, the prince, and the channeler lived a very happy life together, never quite knowing who would turn up at breakfast.

FOR

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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